



boy' label lasted only an hour as he drove his elbow into Dara O'Shea's back before engaging in a gestured showdown with the Irish fans. To heighten the tension, the 40-year-old was shown marching orders for the first time in his international career before being jeered off the field by home supporters. Portugal ended up losing 2-0 and extending its qualification wait, while Ireland stayed in the fight thanks to a brace from Troy Parrott.

In its following game against Armenia, things seemed to be heading south for Portugal at 1-1, but Bruno Fernandes and Joao Neves stepped up with hat-tricks to make it 9-1 and send their side to the World Cup. Ireland, meanwhile, kept its fairytale going, coming from a goal down to beat Hungary 3-2 and seal a playoff spot. Parrott was at the heart of it, scoring all three goals, including a last-minute winner.

Meanwhile, Norway returned to the World Cup for the first time since 1998 after an unblemished qualifying campaign, capped by a 4-1 win against Italy. Although Italy needed to win by at least nine goals to take top spot, it was Norway instead that took its chances and powered through



Leading from the front: Congo captain Chancel Mbemba celebrates his winning penalty in a shootout against Nigeria. REUTERS

Italy's defence with four second-half goals, including a brace for Erling Haaland, who now has 32 goals this season for club and country.

Italy will now have to go through the playoffs to avoid missing a third straight World Cup.

Joining Portugal and Norway at the tournament are Croatia and France. Kylian Mbappe led from the front with a brace as France beat Ukraine 4-0 to secure a spot, while Croatia overturned a one-goal deficit to beat Faroe Islands 3-1 and qualify.

While Europe's World Cup picture took shape, in Africa the race for the playoff spot threw up a couple of surprises. DR Congo stunned giants Cameroon and Nigeria to emerge as the continent's representative for FIFA's six-team Intercontinental Playoff tournament in March, which will send two teams to the World Cup in the United States, Canada and Mexico.

(All results updated as of November 16)